APPROVED ON OCTOBER 7, 2026
BY THE BOARD OF COUNTY COMMISSIONERS
AT THE WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION

Open Session: September 28, 2026
10:00 a.m. - Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Attendance: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron A. Smith convened the Board in Open Session at 10:00 a.m.

1. **OPEN SESSION**
    a. **To review and evaluate the employment-related performance of the chief executive officer of any public body, a public officer, employee or staff member who requests an open hearing.**

Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe, Interim Human Resources Director, explained that the purpose of the hearing was to provide the Commissioners an opportunity to ask questions about the previously issued job-performance concerns and to allow Facilities Director Ryan Johnson to respond. Mr. Johnson confirmed that he requested an open hearing and was prepared to address the matters identified in the notice. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe stated that the Commissioners, rather than Human Resources, would conduct the questioning.

Commissioner Martin began with the County communications system and asked why the condition and urgency of the radio infrastructure had not been more fully communicated to the current Board. Mr. Johnson stated that he had presented the matter during budget discussions, had spoken individually with Commissioners, and had participated in earlier discussions involving the Sheriff, Public Works and Finance. He described the system as obsolete and said a 2024 Motorola proposal and earlier efforts to obtain funding documented the longstanding need for replacement. Commissioners Martin and Richardson emphasized the need for a documented, forward-looking plan, including project priorities, costs and supporting information, to enable Board planning and funding decisions.

Commissioner Martin questioned Mr. Johnson about his absence from the April 2 meeting with the Sheriff and Day Wireless and the status of the Board-approved equipment assessment. Mr. Johnson stated that he was home ill, learned of the meeting shortly beforehand, and had previously expressed concern that a roughly $32,000 assessment would duplicate information already available about the aging system. Commissioner Martin disagreed that the assessment was unnecessary and stated that it supplied information about equipment and facility conditions. Both Commissioners questioned why existing proposals and maintenance information had not been provided to them when the Board sought an assessment. Mr. Johnson acknowledged that he should have furnished the Motorola proposal, while maintaining that he had verbally communicated his concerns and that the County already had relevant information.

Commissioner Richardson then reviewed his July request for an estimated cost for work at the Animal Shelter and questioned the time taken to provide planning information. Mr. Johnson stated that he attempted to obtain cost information, that a reliable estimate for a project exceeding $3 million would require work by design and construction professionals, and that project funding had not been identified. The Commissioners discussed his subsequent use of inflation-adjusted figures from a 2024 estimate and their expectations for timely updates. Mr. Johnson disputed the reference in his notice to a levy for capital upgrades, stating that the Animal Shelter levy funded operations. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe clarified that the document supplied to Mr. Johnson was a notice of investigation, not findings of an investigation.

The Board also discussed written communication and management-meeting attendance. Mr. Johnson acknowledged that he did not regularly attend general management meetings, explaining that he prioritized topics directly involving Facilities and sought specific documentation of concerns. Commissioners Martin and Richardson emphasized that directors should share information across departments and plan proactively. Mr. Johnson stated that Facilities operates subject to Board priorities and available funding.

Commissioner Martin asked about election-day access to the Clerk's Office. Mr. Johnson described automated door schedules and one manual unlocking assignment, and acknowledged a prior staffing oversight and an automated-system malfunction. The Board also questioned Facilities contracting and security planning, including Treasury and the courthouse. Mr. Johnson discussed purchasing thresholds, earlier projects, existing security plans and budget constraints. The parties disagreed about the extent and timing of information that should reach the Board.

At 10:50 a.m., Chair Smith called a five-minute recess.

2. EXECUTIVE SESSION - NOT HELD

a. To review and evaluate the employment-related performance of the chief executive officer of any public body, a public officer, employee or staff member who does not request an open hearing - ORS 192.660(2)(i).

An Executive Session was listed on the agenda but was not convened. Mr. Johnson requested an open hearing, and all discussion on the matter occurred in Open Session.

3. OPEN SESSION CON'D

a. Continuation of the requested open hearing after recess.

The Board reconvened in Open Session at 10:55 a.m. Commissioner Martin questioned the Facilities maintenance process and the condition of older plumbing at the Fairgrounds, including the buildings used by 4-H. Mr. Johnson explained that the Fairgrounds plumbing had been modified over many years and that the allocation of major projects and building responsibilities was ultimately determined by the Board. Commissioner Martin again requested clearer documentation of prospective maintenance needs, including roofing and heating, ventilation and air-conditioning systems.

Mr. Johnson stated that service needs are received by telephone or email, entered into Asset Essentials, prioritized and assigned to technicians. He said safety and security are primary considerations, that recurring preventive-maintenance work is generated through the system, and that other repairs are addressed according to available staffing and funds. In response to questions about building conditions and delayed maintenance, he described a maintenance budget of approximately $300,000 for County facilities and said that urgent failures frequently determine the order of work. Commissioners Martin and Richardson emphasized the importance of documented priority lists and planning ahead for repair and replacement needs.

Commissioner Martin asked about the response to power outages and communications with departments and County tenants. Mr. Johnson stated that he contacts the utility, dispatches Facilities staff, and prioritizes critical operations such as Dispatch and the courts. Commissioner Martin described a tenant's difficulty reaching Facilities during a previous outage and requested at least an acknowledgment or status message. Mr. Johnson said he had returned the call after speaking with the utility and that emergency-response calls must be prioritized. In response to questions regarding ordinary communications, he stated that he attempts to answer emails and voicemail the same day when possible and also responds to calls outside normal working hours.

Mr. Johnson stated that he believed he had responded to the concerns, referred to supporting correspondence from other department heads, requested removal of the notice from his employment record, and asked to receive any additional findings or allegations. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe explained that the Commissioners would review his responses and meet subsequently to consider next steps. No personnel findings, disciplinary determination or other formal action were made at this hearing.

There being no further business, Chair Smith adjourned the meeting at 11:11 a.m.